

YASBANT NEGI



DIVIDED WE STAND: (From left) Debabrata Biswas, Naidu, Gowda, Mayawati, Karat, Bardhan and T.J. Chandrachudhan

THE THIRD AFFRONT

Too many prime ministerial candidates, clashing egos, ideological dissonance and disagreements over seat-sharing arrangements render the much touted alternative alliance a non-starter

■ By Shafi Rahman

When CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat visited JD(S) leader H.D. Deve Gowda last week to convince him about anointing BSP supremo Mayawati as the prime ministerial candidate of the conglomeration of regional parties, the quintessential Marxist was introduced to a celestial prophecy: "My astrologer has predicted that I will become prime minister again". Karat's designer baby is in tatters as too many prime minister hopefuls are banking on constellations as well as political clout in their bid to lead the fledgling Third Front of 10 parties.

With Mayawati insisting that she be declared the prime ministerial

candidate and many regional satraps refusing to hand over leadership, a massive battle of egos has become a constant irritant in the Third Front's effort to take off. After their joint meeting on July 23, the leaders of the 10-party alliance had announced "joint campaigns against the UPA very soon". Even after a month, those campaigns are yet to go off the starting block.

The Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP), All India Forward Bloc, JD(S) and RLD are opposed to projecting Mayawati as the prime ministerial candidate of the new alliance. "We asked Karat about the kind of assurance he can give on Mayawati's future plans. Can he assure us that she won't go with the BJP after the elections?" asked a leader of a junior

Left party. Many in the Left fear that the regional parties may slip into the BJP camp after the elections. Gowda has refused to commit to the Left leaders about his joining the Third Front if Mayawati replaced Samajwadi Party leader Mulayam Singh Yadav as its president. "Currently, the final shape of the alliance is not known. There is no Laxman Rekha to it as of now," said the JD(S) leader post his meeting with Karat.

Also, the seat sharing has become a contentious issue in the new alliance. Mayawati has already announced her plans to field candidates across Uttar Pradesh without conceding even a single seat to the allies. Her party is aiming at bagging at least 80 seats from across the country. When the BSP